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Rossano Sportiello Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Rossano was interviewed via Zoom on July 20, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe at Hamilton College for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm with Rossano Sportiello today from his apartment in Manhattan is it?

RS: That's right. In the West Village.

MR: In the West Village, and I see your piano. You're always near a piano it seems like.

RS: Well you know it's, especially these days I think the piano became my best friend, more than ever.

MR: Yesterday I watched your performance of "Thou Swell."

RS: Oh wow.

MR: It was really swell.

RS: Well you know I have to tell you I was never much technological and I'm still not technological. But I was not into social medias. I believed as far as I'm healthy and I keep practicing I could go places to play music. And nobody would have ever guessed that something like this would happen. At least it was far away. You know unfortunately I was one of those guys that when this mess started to happen that we were hearing about it in February and very early March, I thought that they were making it bigger than what it really was, and of course I was wrong. So I never thought that after thirty years of performing live with a full schedule — thirty years — I never thought that we could get to a stop like this. You know?

MR: Yeah. And it's across the board, you know people who are NEA Jazz Masters can't get a gig as well as the people who are playing in the American Legion on the weekends. It's the same for everybody.

RS: Yeah. Yeah, and so what happened, I was on tour in Europe. The tour started at the end of February and was supposed to go on until the first week of April. All one nighters, you know? But of course at around March 8, 9, 10, we started being bombarded with emails of people cancelling our concerts. And so our last performance was actually on March 13 in Germany. And I was able to get a flight back to New York on March 16. And that was

the end of it. So I stayed I think about four weeks without doing nothing even. Because the first two weeks I was supposed to be quarantined. Right? So I just was locked into the bedroom. My wife was sleeping on the sofa you know. So then the two weeks went by and life was back in a way, so at least I could go to the grocery store with the mask. And so I think another ten days went by and then I told myself, you know, I cannot just keep doing just not playing anymore, not performing anymore. And so I started making every night, one or two videos and posting them on Facebook. Mostly improvisation based on standards. And so because you see my wife also has been working from home, what happened, the only chance for me to really record these clips was at night. And so I had to use the mute on the piano. And so I called it "The Muted Piano Late Night Sessions." I did I think 112 of them.

MR: Wow. Are you talking about the soft pedal?

RS: Yeah. The soft pedal that some upright pianos have, that normally is the middle pedal. You press it down and there is a felt that goes in between the strings and the hammers and it creates like that a very soft, muffled sound that is actually very nice. And I found it in a way very, very jazzy. And so I started recording these videos. I would put on a suit every night with a jacket and a tie you know, and it started almost like a joke. And then people seemed to like it. And they kept watching these videos and I put there a link for donations in case someone — and I have to be honest with you, at first the donation option I didn't even consider it. And then I had some fans writing to me privately saying please post a link for it. And so I didn't know how to do it, because I didn't know what PayPal was. I didn't know what Venmo was, still, because I'm not technological, I'm old school, I get paid either with checks and sometimes with a little cash. So I figured out the PayPal and Venmo and I put it there and now every now and then people will drop something. But you know it's not the money, I think I'm very grateful for people donating some money but the greatest satisfaction came when I got an email from a gentleman that is 97 years old, 97. And he said that I wake up every morning looking for your Mute email. You know? And so I said that's it, no matter what, I'm going to do it. Because this one person, that is 97 years old that loves music and gets up in the morning and wants to see my late night video. You know that means more than anything to me. Then I started to get mails from young piano players, you know? Asking me for suggestions and expressing their desire to learn and so that was another strong motivation. I said I'm happy to show my hands and the way I improvise and all this material is there for anyone to use the way they want. You know if all of a sudden there are ten young piano players that start the so-called stealing phrases and techniques, that's what they are supposed to do. I am happy for that. I hope all this music that I've been posting has helped someone to alleviate all the psychological stress.

MR: Yes. You know during our first interview you said something and I wrote it down, "to play jazz and make it understandable is one of my goals." And it's very curious that you're actually able, in a different way, to accomplish that, the things you're describing.

RS: Well you know it's almost a philosophical problem you know. How many times we listen, look at art and we don't know what's going on. We don't. So it becomes sometimes a decision to say I like it or not. So sometimes we say I like it, sometimes we say I don't like it, but we don't have really a reason because we don't really understand what is going on. And so I always wondered, is there a way to play music in my case, to play music and come up with something that can be beautiful, that can be smart, that can be also new but at the same time enjoyable and understandable. Understandable means even just, even if you're not a musician, you don't know about theory, you don't have perfect pitch. But is there an emotion that goes through and gets to you. That's, I think, what understandable means.

MR: Okay.

RS: And so I'm constantly thinking of that. Every time I perform. Every time I make a recording or play live or make a post I ask myself will this communicate some sort of message? So I hope so.

MR: Well you got me with your "Thou Swell." I mean even from a rhythmic drive, like wow, that made my heart speed up a little bit I think.

RS: Right.

MR: That stride thing, I just like well that's almost impossible what you're doing.

RS: Well you know I mean the stride was I think what got me the most since the very beginning, even when I started playing classical and I didn't know about the existence of jazz. When I would hear someone play that thing with the left hand, I don't know what it was it would just get to me, you know? I don't know if someone would say what is it that got your attention about that left hand? I liked it. You know? I just felt it in my stomach. You know? I don't know. To me one possible explanation is that, that movement of the left hand, bass and chord, oomp pa, oomp pa, oomp pa. In a certain way resembles the very meaning of life, that is the pulse of your heart. You know? The opening and closing of your lungs. So probably at a subconscious level I associate that with the very basic function of life that makes our lives as human beings possible. The rhythmic contraction of the heart and the lungs. That's the only explanation I can give about this sort of attraction I always felt.

MR: Well it got me in the heart.

RS: Well thank you.

MR: Okay. I'm curious, you said you were on tour in Europe. Did you find it necessary to cancel gigs yourself so you could get home?

RS: No. I didn't have to. Just promoters. Even because I'll say one more time, I was not willing to cancel myself because we still were around so many people including doctors that were saying that this wasn't a big deal. You know? There were doctors on TV that they were saying that this was just like a common cold or something, not much worse than a seasonal — and so we listened to that and I think maybe we were hoping that that was the case. But then you know speaking of Facebook, a few days ago it was circulating a post of someone asking if we knew anyone that died with the disease — and I have to say I had quite a few friends and people that I knew that died with the disease. And I had friends that got the disease, some of them went to the hospital and recovered. Some of them they just stayed home. They just had a regular sore throat with a little bit of coughing. A friend of mine just lost the sense of smell for three weeks and that was about the only symptoms. So I have to say probably this is real, because I never had in one certain period of my life four friends dying with the same disease. You know?

MR: And people that meant so much to us, like Bucky and Ruth.

RS: That's right.

MR: Yeah. Did you change your behavior as New York City got worse and now it's getting better?

RS: I didn't change yet my behavior. You know the only thing that maybe I do just a little, I go out a little bit more, you know, but not for fun. I just go out if I need something. Like I've been fooling around with a little bit of recording equipment. I bought a microphone. So I'll go to the B&H Shop by bicycle wearing the mask, and if something all of a sudden comes to my mind, I need a cable, then I'll get the bicycle and go you know. While in the first few weeks I would just go downstairs once a week to buy food. Now I go downstairs to the market every day to buy food, because it's just downstairs. So that's about it.

MR: Do you have any personal thought about why this has occurred now?

RS: I think that we were lucky that a hundred years went by and didn't have such a big pandemic going on. Because I think the last event that this, even that can be considered similar to this was the Spanish flu, even though back then I think the numbers of people that died was unbelievable. Like more than the fatalities of the two wars I've heard. But you know there is something to be said — I saw an interview of an Italian ex-elementary school teacher that she is still alive, I think one hundred and some years old, and she was saying, very smart, very bright still you know, unbelievable. I was very fascinated. She was saying that she went through, as a little child, the Spanish flu and then the wars, they lost everything. The family lost everything in the first war. She lost everything again in the second war. But she said they never felt like we feel today, the sense of anxiety and stress and preoccupation and — never. Life didn't stopped during the war. They would

go dancing normally during the weekends, and then the alarm would go off and they would try to hide in the basements. But then when the alarm would stop they would go up again to the club and keep dancing. You know? And the same thing, I was reading George Shearing's biography you know, during the war in England. Guys — they were going out and play gigs every night. And then the planes would come, the Germans, and drop a few bombs, and of course some people died. But it didn't stop them from running their regular life. So this is something that we should think about. Why is that?

MR: Do you think it's partly because we are bombarded with so much information 24 hours a day that it stifles us?

RS: I think that's the point. I stopped watching television a long time ago. You know, if you ask my wife, you see now they have this new flat screen television and we have one of them. I don't even know how to turn it on. You know there are two remotes apparently, one is for the TV and the other one is for the box. I have no idea which one is which and how it works. Really. You know, so I have to absorb a little bit of television when my wife wants to watch it. But otherwise I'm not going to turn it on. I don't need it you know. And you know the other issue that is very important, and you know but I'm starting to get this very alarming feeling that we don't know anymore where is the truth because you turn on one channel and they tell you one thing. You turn on the other channel, they tell you the opposite. Then you turn on the day after the same channel and they say the opposite of what they were saying the day before. And it's been going on like this now for months. You know we know the problem with the masks. At the beginning there were people that were saying masks are useless. We shouldn't be wearing the masks. Actually some doctors say that the mask will make you sick. Other doctors were saying no you use the mask just to prevent yourself from contaminating the environment. And so they kept going weeks with this issue of the masks. You know? So people is going to go crazy trying to decide what to do and what is right to do. You know I don't know I think in a few years once this will be over, I hope that some scientists they will run a sort of sociological study about all this mess that happened.

MR: Yes. I think historians and sociologists are going to be busy with 2020 for a long time.

RS: Yeah. Because this is beyond the — you know the way that we are bombarded. But it's not only TV. You've got to be careful also in the internet. Now I don't know why, when I turn on my computer and I start the browser, right away I get a pop-up of news. So I don't know how to turn that off you know. But even if you don't want — my phone every morning during the day I get something that pops up and then you click, you put your finger there and you get news. And it's just one news after the other, just bad stuff happening. You know?

MR: The people that are watching this later on won't know that it took me fifteen minutes to make this Zoom happen today. I'm wondering if both of us weren't sort of born in the wrong era.

RS: Well you know we just kept doing things, up to now, and we made a living, that did not require all this equipment, you know? You know I just made a living, traveling, and going in front of an audience and play the piano since I was 16 years old. I'm 46 now. I repeat myself. Thirty years. So I think unless you are very passionate about technology then if you don't need it you don't need it. I still have friends that they don't have a cell phone because they don't need it. They do a business, a family-run business and they don't need a cell phone. They just have a landline phone. They barely know how to open a computer. And just because now they are imposing that you do some business with emails, you know, so that the age of seventy some years old they had to learn how to do emails. Otherwise they would have been perfectly happy still writing letters you know.

MR: Every once in a while in this country we read about Italian politics. And you know they have their share of issues and scandals and so forth. As that is your native country I wonder how our politics compare to what you grew up with?

RS: Well the scandals were always there. And I think that in the 70s and the early 80s the situation was even much worse because we shouldn't forget that we had the problem of internal terrorism in Italy. So we had organized crime that was killing judges almost every week you know. One of our prime ministers, Aldo Moro, was killed by the extreme left movement. So we had terrible things happening way worse than today. But again, for some reason, you know I was little so I don't remember much, but my parents, when I talk to them they say that there was a joy of living. You know? Even though they would blow up every now and then a train station, blow up a square in Milan, you know and people getting killed like that. But no one felt oppressed by this kind of anxiety that we are feeling today. Even though those times now, watching now, they seem to be worse and more dangerous than now. So again, what is that? You know I think you have a point, it's just the fact that all day long people are watching TV and being bombarded. Because back then a TV would be — that's another issue — we would turn on the TV only in the evening, having dinner, watching the news. And maybe in the early morning before going to school they had a little show of cartoons that we would watch as kids. And then in the afternoon we would come back from school and we were allowed maybe one hour to watch TV in the afternoon. Otherwise we would turn it off. And we would turn it off even because there was an awareness about the consumption of electricity you know. I remember my grandmother, I used to have one of those cute electric trains, you know, that my father bought for us. And once I took it to my grandmother and so I plugged it in, I put it together and I started playing. And then after about a half hour my

grandmother said, "Now we stop because the electricity is expensive." And that was perfectly normal. We accepted that. Now if you tell a kid, you know, now you stop doing the videogame because the electricity is expensive, they are looking like you're crazy. They're going to call the number, 9-1-1, say my father is going crazy.

MR: I know the power went out in our house the other night and it was like what do we do? It was like a crisis.

RS: Yes, but think, we are talking about not that long ago you know, the early 80s, I was 6, 7, 8 years old. And this was our life. Everything, nothing would go to waste. Nothing would go to waste. And I'll tell you one more thing. And I'm not afraid of sharing some very personal matters. In the first apartment that I remember living with my parents, that is where I was born, we didn't have a telephone. We got our first landline phone I think when I was 7 years old. And also until the age of 7 we didn't have warm water. We only had cold water. So in the summer it wasn't a big deal but in winter we would wash our faces with cold water in the morning and we would take a bath. My mother would put some big pots of water to boil you know, and then mix it with the cold water in the bathtub. And I did that until 7 and I don't remember, I don't remember no one of us ever complained about that.

MR: It's just what it was.

RS: Yeah. And we were always clean. Always clean. Always clean clothes. I can't even tell you how things are changed, and in spite now we have a much more comfortable life but why is that that we feel so much nostalgic about those years? What is that?

MR: Does the nostalgia come out in your piano playing?

RS: I think it's gotten more and more the tendency to do that, but sometimes I have to control myself because I end up playing music that is too sad, sometimes I leave a bad impression. So I have to think about that you know, because if you start to try to put into music some of your emotion than unfortunately I might have the tendency to go toward a little bit of darkness and I don't want to do that. You know? So I think maybe now more than ever we need to try to lift our spirits. We need to try to inspire other people for the best in the future to come you know. Because otherwise if we get into this loop of negativity it's a disaster. Maybe I'm wrong. You know? Maybe I'm wrong.

MR: I think the 97-year-old fellow who tunes into you every day will think you're right.

RS: Yeah. I think so too you know. You know I grew up with my grandparents, all four of them. And they had a long life. So I was already an adult and still having four of them around. And there isn't one single day that goes by without me thinking of my grandparents you know, and whenever I have to make a decision about something or I have a problem I try to daydream as they could be here and I could ask them what would you do, what do you think. And it seems to me sometimes I hear their voices you know.

And the most beautiful thing is that I still remember very clearly their common sense. This is people that, they had good common sense. These were people, a generation of people that could weigh, in reality, better than us. Maybe because they went through the war and they saw things that — I'm sorry I was — it was toward the end of one of my grandparents, the paternal grandfather that I asked him about wartime. And I never did before. And he told me things that I would have never imagined you know. Like being starving. Like walking in the snow without proper shoes for days, you know? And things like this. So these people, they had to have a better approach with reality. The coping mechanism with reality and being — developing good common sense, that with most of us is missing now.

MR: Rossano, it sounds like there's a suite of original compositions waiting to come out from you. That's what I think.

RS: Actually I've been composing during these months.

MR: Good.

RS: So what happens, here is another story. So already three months ago I sent out a newsletter from my website saying that I was willing to do private concerts on Zoom, that I was even willing to write songs under commission. So if someone thought that they wanted a song written for themselves or for someone else, and I got three or four people answering to that, and they asked me, you know I would like to have one song composed for my daughter, one song composed for my husband, I would like one song composed for my friend. And so I started more and more to sit at the piano with a piece of manuscript paper and a pencil and music started to come out of my fingers first, and then I would write it down. As soon as I would get a good idea, and so now I have quite a few. So I am preparing now actually, actually I will go in the recording studio this coming Thursday and Friday to do a new piano solo record for Arbors Records.

MR: Oh wonderful.

RS: And so I'm going to include a few of these new compositions in this record.

MR: Good.

RS: But I think it's nice — the thing about composing is you come up with the song that you like and then you tell yourself I did this. You know? So I've got my own tunes that I can improvise on now. And so it's nice to throw it out there and see what other people think about it, without much expectations, but something nice to do.

MR: Yeah. Well I appreciate your sharing your personal feelings and I'm going to end this by saying I am anticipating when you finally are able to get back and play a real gig on a wonderful piano without the soft pedal engaged, that you are going to get a surge throughout your body. And I hope I'm there.

RS: Well I hope so. It was very, very kind of you for you to do this, and I think this is the second interview that I've got a chance to do with you and I have to say that I always enjoy it very much because I love your questions, I love to talk to you, and I feel it also like your questions are inspiring sometimes you know. And that's very important because there is nothing worse than when you get an interview and you are asked questions and you really don't feel any kind of connection with the interviewer you know. But with you it's been always a pleasure, really. So anytime.

MR: Well thank you, that means a lot.

RS: Thank you for giving me this chance to express a little bit of my thoughts with my words and not only just with my hands.

MR: Good. I encourage you to stay closer to the piano and stay away from that television.

RS: Absolutely. There is no danger for that. All right?

MR: Thank you very much.

RS: I wish you all the best and we'll be in touch.

MR: Okay. Over and out.

RS: All right. Take care.

MR: Bye.

RS: Bye.